Fluid Around the Lung (Pleural Effusion)

A guide for you and your family

Your chest x-ray showed a moderate amount of fluid in the space around your **right lung**. The medical name for this is a **pleural effusion** (say: PLOOR-ul eh-FYOO-zhun). This page explains what that means. It does not replace talking with your care team.

What is a pleural effusion?

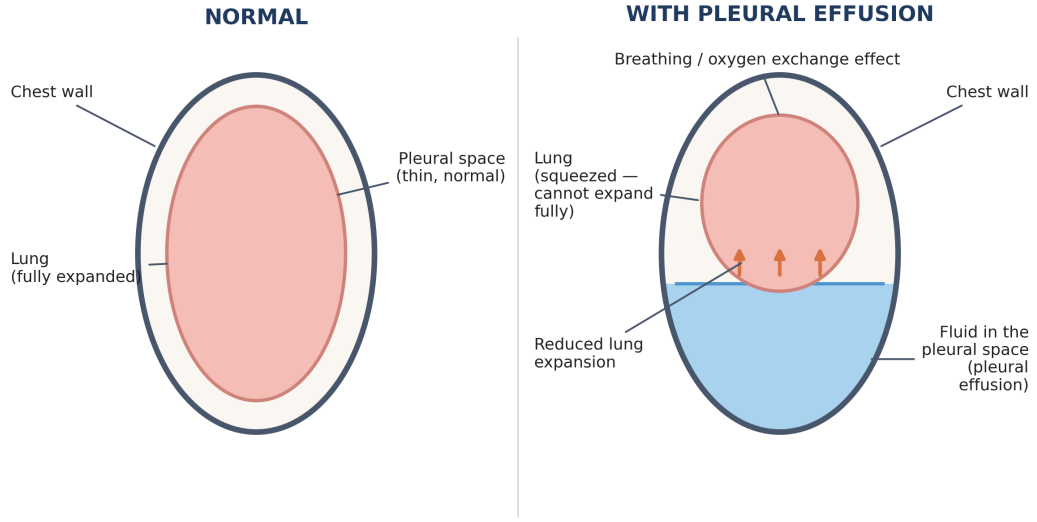
Your lung sits next to the **chest wall** (the ribs and muscles around your chest). Between the lung and the chest wall is a thin gap called the **pleural space**. Normally this space holds only a tiny bit of fluid. A pleural effusion means extra fluid has built up in that space, around the **outside** of the lung. This fluid is outside the lung. It is **not** fluid inside your breathing tubes, and it is **not** your lung filling up.

Why can this affect my breathing?

When you breathe in, your lung needs room to expand (get bigger). Extra fluid takes up room and can press on the lung, so the lung may not expand all the way. Because of this, fluid around the lung can:

- make it harder to take a full, deep breath
- add to shortness of breath (feeling out of breath)
- add to a cough

How much it affects you is different for each person.



Less room to expand means less air moves in, which can reduce the oxygen passing into the blood.

How fluid around the lung limits expansion and oxygen exchange.

When to get help right away

Tell your nurse right away — or call 911 — if you have any of these:

- Breathing that suddenly gets much worse, or severe trouble breathing
- Chest pain
- Lips or face turning blue or gray
- Confusion, or trouble staying awake
- Fainting, or feeling like you may pass out
- Not able to speak a full sentence because you are too short of breath

What happens next

Your care team needs more information before deciding what to do. The x-ray alone does not show your vital signs, blood test results, or oxygen levels, and it does not include a treatment plan. Your provider will talk with you about what this fluid means for you and the next steps. Please ask your nurse or provider any questions.

This handout is for learning only. It is not medical advice or a treatment plan. Please follow the instructions from your own care team.